

Lesson 08:

Linear Coherence of a Passage: Surah Al -Baqarah

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The theme of life manifests itself in refined ways through the examples of an anchor, Prophet Ibrahim (PBUH) and Namrud, ruined towns, revived dead birds, and sprouting seeds in ayat 255 to 261 of Surah Al-Baqarah.

Case Study: Surah Al-Baqarah (255-261)

اللَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ الْحَيُّ الْقَيُّومُ ۚ لَا تَأْخُذُهُ سِنَّةٌ وَلَا نَوْمٌ ۚ لَهُ مَا فِي السَّمَاوَاتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ ۚ مَنْ ذَا الَّذِي يَشْفَعُ عِنْدَهُ إِلَّا بِإِذْنِهِ ۚ يَعْلَمُ مَا بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَمَا خَلْفَهُمْ ۚ وَلَا يُحِيطُونَ بِشَيْءٍ مِّنْ عِلْمِهِ إِلَّا بِمَا شَاءَ ۚ وَسِعَ كُرْسِيُّهُ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ ۚ وَلَا يَئُودُهُ حِفْظُهُمَا ۚ وَهُوَ الْعَلِيُّ الْعَظِيمُ ﴿٢٥٥﴾ لَا إِكْرَاهَ فِي الدِّينِ ۚ قَدْ تَبَيَّنَ الرُّشْدُ مِنَ الْغَيِّ ۚ فَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِالطَّاغُوتِ وَيُؤْمِنْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدِ اسْتَمْسَكَ بِالْعُرْوَةِ الْوُثْقَىٰ لَا انْفِصَامَ لَهَا ۚ وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ ﴿٢٥٦﴾ اللَّهُ وَلِيُّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا يُخْرِجُهُم مِّنَ الظُّلُمَاتِ إِلَى النُّورِ ۚ وَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا أُولَئِكَ هُمُ الطَّاغُوتُ يُخْرِجُونَهُم مِّنَ النُّورِ إِلَى الظُّلُمَاتِ ۚ أُولَئِكَ أَصْحَابُ النَّارِ ۚ هُمْ فِيهَا خَالِدُونَ ﴿٢٥٧﴾ أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِي حَاجَّ إِبْرَاهِيمَ فِي رَبِّهِ أَنْ آتَاهُ اللَّهُ الْمُلْكَ إِذْ قَالَ إِبْرَاهِيمُ رَبِّيَ الَّذِي يُحْيِي وَيُمِيتُ قَالَ أَنَا أُحْيِي وَأُمِيتُ ۚ قَالَ إِبْرَاهِيمُ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْتِي بِالشَّمْسِ مِنَ الْمَشْرِقِ فَأْتِ بِهَا مِنَ الْمَغْرِبِ فَبُهِتَ الَّذِي كَفَرَ ۚ وَاللَّهُ لَا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الظَّالِمِينَ ﴿٢٥٨﴾ أَوْ كَالَّذِي مَرَّ عَلَى قَرْيَةٍ وَهِيَ خَاوِيَةٌ عَلَى عُرُوشِهَا قَالَ أَنَّى يُحْيِي هَذِهِ اللَّهُ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا ۚ فَأَمَاتَهُ اللَّهُ مِائَةَ عَامٍ ثُمَّ بَعَثَهُ ۚ قَالَ كَمْ لَبِثْتَ ۚ قَالَ لَبِثْتُ يَوْمًا أَوْ بَعْضَ يَوْمٍ ۚ قَالَ بَلْ لَبِثْتَ مِائَةَ عَامٍ فَانْظُرْ إِلَى طُعَامِكَ وَسَرَابِكَ ۚ لَمْ يَتَسَنَّهْ ۚ وَانْظُرْ إِلَى حِمَارِكَ وَلِنَجْعَلَكَ آيَةً لِّلنَّاسِ ۚ وَانْظُرْ إِلَى الْعِظَامِ كَيْفَ نُنشِئُهَا ثُمَّ نَكْسُوهَا لَحْمًا ۚ فَلَمَّا تَبَيَّنَ لَهُ قَالَ أَعْلَمُ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ ﴿٢٥٩﴾ وَإِذْ قَالَ إِبْرَاهِيمُ رَبِّ أَرِنِي كَيْفَ تُحْيِي الْمَوْتَىٰ ۚ قَالَ أُولَئِكَ ثُبُورٌ ۚ قَالَ بَلَىٰ وَلَئِن لَّبِثْتُ إِلَّا عِندَ اللَّهِ غَرَضٌ ۚ قَالَ فَاذْهَبْ ۚ أَزْبَعَهُ مِّنَ الظُّلُمَاتِ فَصَرَّهِنَّ إِلَيْكَ ۚ ثُمَّ اجْعَلْ عَلَى كُلِّ جَبَلٍ مِّنْهُنَّ جُزْءًا ۚ ثُمَّ ادْعُهُنَّ يَأْتِينَكَ سَعْيًا ۚ وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ ﴿٢٦٠﴾ مَثَلُ الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوَالَهُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ كَمَثَلِ حَبَّةٍ أَتَتْ سَنَابِلَ فِي كُلِّ سُنبُلَةٍ مِّائَةُ حَبَّةٍ ۚ وَاللَّهُ يُضَاعِفُ لِمَنْ يَشَاءُ ۚ وَاللَّهُ وَاسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ ﴿٢٦١﴾

Translation

255. Allah - there is absolutely none to be worshipped/obeyed/loved except for He - the Living, the Establisher of [all] existence. Neither drowsiness overtakes Him nor sleep. To Him exclusively belongs whatever is in the skies and whatever is on the earth. Who dares to intercede before Him except by His permission? He knows what lies ahead of them and what lies behind them, and they encompass nothing of His knowledge except for what He wills. His Kursi [i.e. throne] extends over the skies and the earth, and guarding both of them does not exhaust Him. And He is the Most High, the Most Great.
256. There is absolutely no compulsion in [the matter of] religion. The correct/straight way has been made abundantly clear/distinct from the deviated [course]. So whoever

disbelieves in the forces of rebellion [Taghut] and [instead] believes in Allah has held on [for dear life] to the strongest anchor whose chain has no break in it. And Allah is Hearing and Knowing.

257. Allah is the protective friend of those who believe. He brings them out from darkneses into the light. And those who disbelieve - their protective friends are the rebellious. They take them out of the light into darkneses. Those are the people of the Fire [in which] they will remain.
258. Have you not considered the one who debated viciously against Ibrahim about his Master [merely] because Allah had given him kingship? When Ibrahim said, "My Master is the one who gives life and causes death," he said, "I [am the one who] gives life and causes death." Ibrahim said, "Certainly, Allah brings up the sun from the east, so bring it up from the west." So the disbeliever was stumped [by astonishment], and Allah does not guide the wrongdoing people.
259. Or [consider such an example] as the one who passed by a town which had turned over its rooftops [i.e. completely dilapidated/fallen into ruin a long time]. He said, "How can Allah bring this to life after its death?" So Allah caused him to die for a hundred years; then He revived him. He said, "How long have you remained?" The man said, "I have remained a day or part of a day." He said, "Rather, you have remained one hundred years. Look at your food and your drink; it has not changed with time. And look at your donkey; and We [have done so to] make you a miracle for the people. And look at the bones [of this donkey] - how We will raise them, then We will dress them with flesh." So when it [all] became clear to him, he said, "I know that Allah is completely capable/in control over all things."
260. And [remember] when Ibrahim said, "My Master, show me how You give life to the dead." [Allah] said, "Have you not [already] believed?" He said, "Of course, but [I ask] only to my heart at ease." [Allah] said, "Take four [kinds of] birds and incline them back [i.e. train them back] to yourself. Then [after slaughtering them] put on each hill a portion of them; then call them - they will come to you in haste. And know that Allah is the Ultimate Authority and Wise."
261. The example of those who spend their wealth in the path of Allah is like the example of a single seed [of grain] which sprouts seven ears of grain; in each ear is a hundred [more] seeds. And Allah multiplies for whom He wills. And Allah is all-Encompassing and Knowing.

Connection: Progression of an idea

One of the themes being developed in these ayat is the theme of life.

- (2:255) Allah is **الْحَيُّ**, the Living – life and death are in His hands; He is the source of all life.
- Allah shows a progression of ideas and teaches multiple lessons about **الْحَيُّ** using different examples.

Anchor (and sea) imagery (2:256-257)

- When someone believes in Allah the Living, he is holding on to an anchor. This imagery suggests a person being off a ship, drowning, and about to die – the anchor keeps him alive, afloat and in the light.
- Similarly, we are holding on to the anchor of faith to keep us alive.
- If we were to let go of the anchor, we would drown into the depths of the sea. The deeper we go, the darker it gets. Taghut wants us to drown into multiple darknesses. The sea imagery is referenced in Surah An-Nur:

أَوْ كَظُلُمَاتٍ فِي بَحْرٍ لُّجِّيٍّ يَغْشَاهُ مَوْجٌ مِّنْ فَوْقِهِ مَوْجٌ مِّنْ فَوْقِهِ سَحَابٌ ۚ ظُلُمَاتٌ بَعْضُهَا فَوْقَ بَعْضٍ إِذَا أَخْرَجَ يَدُهُ لَمْ يَكَدْ يَرَاهَا ۚ وَمَنْ لَّمْ يَجْعَلِ اللَّهُ لَهُ نُورًا فَمَا لَهُ مِن نُّورٍ ﴿٤٠﴾ (24:40)

- Or [they are] like darknesses within an unfathomable sea which is covered by waves, upon which are waves, over which are clouds - darknesses, some of them upon others. When one puts out his hand [therein], he can hardly see it. And he to whom Allah has not granted light - for him there is no light.

- Lesson: **الْحَيُّ** will take those who believe out from darkness into light. He is our Protective Friend (**وَلِيُّ**).

Prophet Ibrahim and Namrud (2:258)

- Prophet Ibrahim stands in front of King Namrud and declares, “My Master is the one who gives life and gives death.” When Namrud denied, he bravely challenged him: “Allah brings the sun from the east, why don’t you bring it from the west?”
- Lesson: When you internalize **إِلَّا هُوَ الْحَيُّ الْقَيُّومُ**, you can stand in front of the one who can execute you and still say, “Allah gives life.” You will no longer fear for your life in front of anyone else. You become brave in the face of the most tyrannical, knowing that Allah protects your life and you’re holding on to the anchor that will never break.

Ruined towns (2:259)

- Parallel for today - the ummah is so corrupted, how can it ever come back to being good again?
- Lesson: Have hope that Allah can revive and restore anything. He is capable over all things (**اللَّهُ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ**).

Dead birds being brought to life (2:260)

- Lesson: This is not the only life there is. Just like the birds, we will be brought back to life by the Living. One day, Allah will call us and we will be flying back to Him. He is the Ultimate Authority (**عَزِيزٌ**) and Wise (**حَكِيمٌ**).

Seed (2:261)

- Lesson: Allah will take our deeds/charities and pour life into them. Just the way He gives life to a seed that is buried underground, He can take our actions (that we may never even see the effects of) and give life to it – and each seed will expand and produce a hundred more seeds. Allah is Vast (وَاسِعٌ) and Knowledgeable (عَلِيمٌ) in the way He gives life.

Concluding Remarks: This notion of progressive ideas inside passages is one of the dimensions of the logic of the Quran and is a very powerful one. Allah does not advocate knowing the Quran (we don't see as much أَفَلَا تَعْلَمُونَ – “Why don't you know?”), rather He advocates thinking, pondering, and reflecting (أَفَلَا تَعْقِلُونَ – “Why don't you think?”; أَفَلَا يَتَذَكَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ – “Why don't they ponder/reflect over the Quran?”). When that happens, only then will revelation come to life for us.